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1 Emerging Powers in International Politics

he 21st century is marked by an increased attention to the appeal and positive image of a country as instruments of influence in the international arena [2]. There has appeared the concept of soft power, whose author, U.S [10]. political scientist Joseph Nye described it as “the ability to get what you want through attraction rather than coercion or payments [6].” A nation’s image secures attractiveness and trust in a country, playing a crucial role as the key soft power component [7]. Therefore, the efforts of states along this line relate not so much to the sphere of culture and information as to geopolitics [8].

2 Atomic Force Microscopy, a Powerful Tool in Microbiology

Understanding the functions of microbial cell surfaces requires knowledge of their structural and physical properties [3]. Electron microscopy has long been recognized as a key technique in microbiology to elucidate cell surface ultrastructure [4]. An exciting achievement has been the development of cryotechniques which allow high-resolution imaging of cell structures in conditions close to the native state [5]. Yet direct observation in aqueous solution remained impossible. Because of the small size of microorganisms, the physical properties of their surfaces have been difficult to study [9]. Quantitative and qualitative information on physical properties can be obtained by electron microscopy techniques, X-ray photoelectron spectroscopy, infrared spectroscopy, contact angle, and electrophoretic mobility measurements [1].

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